

Small Businesses Say US TikTok Ban Would Hurt Them

As the date nears for a possible U.S. ban on the video sharing service TikTok, some small companies are saying such a ban would hurt their business.

The U.S. Justice Department has ordered TikTok's China-based parent, ByteDance, to sell the social media app by January 19 or face the ban. Lawyers for ByteDance and TikTok have sought legal action to temporarily block the Justice Department's order.

The Supreme Court is expected to consider the matter in January. President-elect Donald Trump, who takes office January 20, has asked the Supreme Court to delay a ban to permit solving the problem through "political means."

U.S. officials have long warned that TikTok presents national security concerns. The government accuses ByteDance of sharing user data with China's government. Critics have said China could also use TikTok to spread misinformation and that material published on the service can harm the mental health of young users.

TikTok has repeatedly denied the accusations. The company has said it sees the app as an important tool to support Americans' right to free speech.

Industry experts have said a U.S. ban on TikTok could affect millions of small businesses that use the service to grow.

TikTok launched in the United States in 2016. Since then, many small business owners have been using it in different ways. These include marketing and advertising campaigns to introduce new products. Many companies also sell goods directly through the app.

TikTok's own estimates suggest small businesses currently using the service would lose more than \$1 billion in revenue in a single month if the ban goes into effect.

One example of how TikTok can be used to quickly grow a business is the experience of Desiree Hill. She is the owner of Crown's Corner Mechanic in Conyers, Georgia.

She told the Associated Press that sharing videos of her work on TikTok helped spread the word online about her business. As a result, the app made her services so popular she was able to open her own shop with five employees 18 months ago.

"Every day I get at least two to three customers that have seen me on TikTok, watched my videos and wanted to become a customer," Hill said.

If a ban on TikTok is established, many businesses would likely move to other services to reach customers. Instagram Reels, Snapchat and YouTube Shorts are three possibilities. Many small companies already use those apps. But business experts say it might be harder to get teens who have long used TikTok to start using other apps.

Another way for businesses to reduce the effects of a ban would be for them to build a strong base of customers who are willing to provide their contact emails or phone numbers. That permits owners to reach out directly to users with new offers and other marketing messages.

Hill, of Crown Corner Mechanics, worries that other services would not reach as many possible customers as TikTok. She said she is already using YouTube, Instagram and Facebook, but has not been getting the same results.

“I am worried because there is no preparation for this,” Hill told the AP. She added, “If I lose TikTok, I will lose a large part of my business or I will lose my ability to grow anymore.”

Crystal Lister uses TikTok for her business, called Mommy and Me: The Listers, in Cypress, Texas. The company offers interactive educational training in subjects including technology and science. Now, she is seeking to move her offerings to YouTube and Instagram Reels but says TikTok is easier to use.

“It is going to be a challenge if TikTok is banned because we’re losing kind of all the functionality you want,” Lister said. These could include video creation methods and the ability to spread product details through social media. “So we’ll have to use many other platforms to supplement what TikTok did in one.”

I’m Bryan Lynn.

The Associated Press reported this story. Bryan Lynn adapted the report for VOA Learning English.

Quiz - Small Businesses Say US TikTok Ban Would Hurt Them

Vocabulary

app - n. โปรแกรมคอมพิวเตอร์ขนาดเล็กที่สามารถติดตั้งบนโทรศัพท์มือถือหรืออุปกรณ์อิเล็กทรอนิกส์อื่น ๆ

customer - n. บุคคลหรือองค์กรที่ซื้อสินค้าหรือบริการจากร้านค้าหรือธุรกิจ

interactive - adj. ซึ่งมีการโต้ตอบกันระหว่างผู้คน

challenge - n. สิ่งที่ยากที่ทดสอบความสามารถหรือความมุ่งมั่นของบุคคล

functionality - n. วิธีการทำงานของบางสิ่ง

supplement - v. เพิ่มเติมเพื่อให้บางสิ่งใหญ่ขึ้นหรือดีขึ้น

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the primary concern expressed by small companies regarding a potential U.S. ban on TikTok?

- A) It would lead to a decrease in advertising costs.
- B) It would hurt their business operations and growth.
- C) It would force them to hire more employees.
- D) It would improve their national security.

2. What action has the U.S. Justice Department ordered TikTok's parent company, ByteDance, to take?

- A) To expand its operations in the U.S.
- B) To share user data with the U.S. government.
- C) To sell the social media app or face a ban.
- D) To pay a large fine by January 19.

3. What approach has President-elect Donald Trump suggested for dealing with the potential TikTok ban?

- A) Immediate implementation of the ban.
- B) Legal action against ByteDance.
- C) Delaying the ban to find a solution through “political means.”
- D) Requiring TikTok to move its headquarters to the U.S.

4. According to U.S. officials, what are the main national security concerns associated with TikTok?

- A) Its high data usage and server costs.
- B) The potential for sharing user data with China's government and spreading misinformation.
- C) Its dominance over other social media platforms in the U.S.
- D) The lack of innovation in its video creation tools.

5. How has TikTok responded to the accusations made by U.S. officials regarding national security and data sharing?

- A) It admitted to sharing some user data but promised to stop.
- B) It offered a compromise to the U.S. government.
- C) It repeatedly denied the accusations and stated it supports free speech.
- D) It announced plans to sell ByteDance to a U.S. company.

6. What is the projected impact of a U.S. ban on TikTok, according to industry experts?

- A) It would significantly increase competition among social media apps.
- B) It would only affect a small percentage of large corporations.
- C) It could affect millions of small businesses that rely on the service for growth.
- D) It would lead to new job opportunities in the tech sector.

7. Besides marketing and advertising campaigns, what is another common way small business owners use TikTok as mentioned in the article?

- A) For internal company communication.
- B) For recruiting new employees.
- C) For selling goods directly through the app.
- D) For conducting market research surveys.

8. What is TikTok's own estimated financial loss for small businesses in a single month if a ban is enforced?

- A) Less than \$500 million.
- B) Exactly \$1 billion.
- C) More than \$1 billion in revenue.
- D) Approximately \$750 million.

9. Who is Desiree Hill, and what kind of business does she own?

- A) A tech expert owning a software development company.
- B) The owner of Crown's Corner Mechanic in Georgia.
- C) A marketing consultant specializing in social media.
- D) A VOA Learning English reporter.

10. How did TikTok specifically help Desiree Hill's business grow, leading to a significant milestone?

- A) It connected her with large corporate clients.
- B) It provided her with free advertising credits.
- C) It helped spread word about her business, enabling her to open her own shop with five employees.
- D) It offered her exclusive discounts on auto parts.

11. How many new customers does Desiree Hill typically acquire each day directly from her TikTok presence?

- A) One new customer.

- B) At least two to three customers.
- C) Five to ten customers.
- D) Dozens of customers.

12. What specific difficulty do business experts predict regarding a shift to other apps if TikTok is banned, particularly concerning young users?

- A) Other apps are too expensive for small businesses.
- B) Other apps lack the same video quality as TikTok.
- C) It might be harder to get teens who are accustomed to TikTok to start using other apps.
- D) Other apps have stricter content moderation policies.

13. What alternative strategy is suggested for businesses to minimize the impact of a TikTok ban and maintain direct customer communication?

- A) Focusing solely on traditional print advertising.
- B) Building a strong customer base willing to provide contact emails or phone numbers.
- C) Developing their own independent social media platform.
- D) Partnering with larger tech companies for marketing.

14. Why is Desiree Hill concerned about using other social media platforms like YouTube, Instagram, and Facebook as alternatives to TikTok?

- A) She finds them too complicated to use.
- B) They require a paid subscription to reach customers.
- C) She has not been getting the same customer reach and results as with TikTok.
- D) Her target audience is not present on those platforms.

15. What is Desiree Hill's ultimate concern if TikTok is banned, as stated in the article?

- A) She will have to close her shop temporarily.
- B) She will lose a large part of her business or her ability to grow.
- C) She will need to significantly increase her marketing budget.
- D) She will be forced to move her business to another state.